At the Gates of Tower II

I. The Sandstone Sanctuary

At the western margin of the salt playa rise the colossal ramparts of Tower II. Here, carved deep into the sheer red cliffs, stands the Sandstone Sanctuary of the Oracle. Fluted columns of living rock frame an ancient archway sealed by heavy bronze gates. In the shadow of the portico stands the Sanctuary Servant, an elder of the Order guarding the threshold with an iron staff topped by a celestial star-sight.

II. The Demand of the Five Seals

No traveler may step beyond the gates without offering proof of their survey. When I presented the carved stone seal recovered from the dry riverbed, the guardian studied its geometry in silence, then pointed his staff to the five empty sockets set into the arch: «You have found the first seal by following the dry wash, but four still sleep in stone. Five sacred cairns were raised by our founders to measure this desert. Return to the sands and complete the meridian survey, or these gates remain closed forever.»

III. The Great Circuit

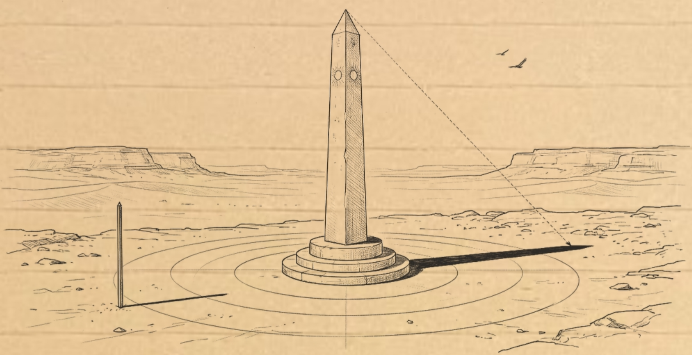
Cairn I	Cairn II	Cairn III	Cairn IV	Cairn V
Seal acquired	Seal missing	Seal missing	Seal missing	Seal missing
River Wash	Sun Monolith	Sandstone Labyrinth	Canyon Sentry	Solar Altar Arch

The initial hunch by the dry wash was only the first link. To unlock the Sanctuary and stand before the Oracle, we must traverse the full expanse of the Grand Desert Map and recover each missing seal from its landmark. Our course is set north-north-east, toward the shadow of the Sun Monolith.

The Sun Monolith & Cairn II

I. The Ridge of the Sun

On the high north-eastern ridge stands the Sun Monolith, an ancient obelisk of red sandstone carved by the founders of the Order. At its foot rests Cairn II, a stepped pedestal surrounded by a radial pavement of concentric rings. Here, where the desert horizon stretches unbroken, the architects calibrated their meridian surveys by measuring the shadows cast at true solar noon.

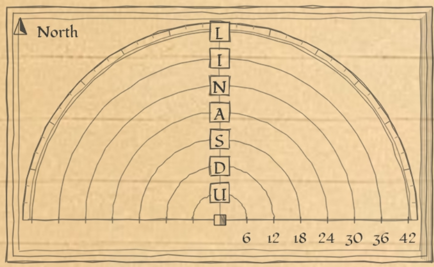


II. The Rules of the Survey

1. The Law of Proportion - At any hour, every upright marker casts a shadow proportional to its height. The surveyor's staff stands two paces tall; the Monolith rises twenty-four paces. Determine the Monolith's shadow for each entry in the ledger.
2. The Meridian Rings - At true solar noon, shadows fall due north across Cairn II. Each concentric ring on the dial marks a measured distance in paces from the Monolith at the center.
3. The Order of the Sigil - Locate the ring for each calculated shadow. The letter tablet carved upon that ring yields one character of the sigil, following the ledger from Noon I to VII.

III. The Seven Noons

Noon	Staff shadow paces	Monolith shadow paces	Dial letter
I	1.5		
II	0.5		
III	2.5		
IV	1		
V	3		
VI	2		
VII	3.5		



The dial of Cairn II (rings in paces)
The Monolith stands at the centre.

The Sigil of Cairn II:

I	II	III	IV	V	VI	VII

Transcribe the seven-letter sigil to align the meridian survey and claim the seal of Cairn II.